

1:1.63–2.6/14–100 ASPH designation, combining ultra-wide, primary, telephoto and periscope optics co-engineered with Leica. On paper, it remains one of the most ambitious and versatile smartphone camera systems currently available in India.

Main camera: the 1-inch advantage

The primary camera pairs a 50 MP Light Fusion 1050L sensor, a 1-inch type built with LOFIC (Lateral Overflow Integration Capacitor) technology with a fast f/1.67 Leica Summilux lens and optical image stabilisation. A sensor of this physical size pulls in more light, produces more dynamic range and delivers an optical depth of field that smaller sensors can approximate in software but cannot replicate naturally.

In daylight, the results are crisp and natural, free of the hyper-sharpened, over-saturated quality that betrays many competing flagship cameras. The skin tones are neutral, facial detail is well-rendered and in high-contrast scenes the sensor balances bright highlights and deep shadows well.

The 1-inch advantage is most apparent in low light. Night shots preserve the subtle tonal transitions that smaller sensors tend to lose like the colour gradients in a twilight sky, the warm quality of artificial lighting at dusk. The noise reduction is effective without being aggressive.

The 2x in-sensor zoom: an everyday favourite

Cropping into the centre of the 50 MP



sensor at 2x gives 46 mm equivalent results, and this has been the most-used focal length in my use, particularly for food and tabletop photography. The reason is straightforward: shooting close subjects at 23 mm introduces barrel distortion that subtly warps proportions.

At 46 mm, a dish shot overhead is sharp edge-to-edge and proportioned accurately. Textures in paint, fabric, food surfaces are retained with natural fidelity and in low light this focal length holds up better than equivalent digital crops from competing devices.

The showstopper: 200 MP continuous optical zoom

Rather than a single fixed telephoto, the 200 MP Samsung ISOCELL HPE sensor sits behind a continuous optical zoom lens covering 75–100 mm equivalent with the aperture shifting from f/2.39 to f/2.96 across the range.

The practical advantage that you get is when you want to frame a subject at exactly 3.5x or 3.8x precisely and the 17 Ultra gives you that with full optical quality. At 75 mm, the background blur is smooth enough and at 100 mm, the 200 MP resolution compensates for the narrower aperture and the OIS handles the handshake amplification that telephoto focal lengths tend to exaggerate so the illuminated building facades at night remain sharp and well-detailed.



Digital zoom from the 200 MP sensor extends the usable reach considerably. At 8.6x, images of flowers, architectural stonework and building facades hold up well in adequate light with some sharpening applied to compensate for the crop.

Shadow detail at this reach can turn soft. At 17.2x, AI upscaling is more visible and fine details take on a slightly softened quality, but getting a usable image at this reach on a smartphone remains an impressive capability, should you ever need it.

Portrait mode across all focal lengths benefits from precise edge detection. Be it thin-stemmed flower subjects, hair or fine structural detail, all are handled accurately.

–Siddharth Chauhan

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 8 Gen 5 | RAM: 16 GB LPDDR6X | Storage: 512 GB / 1 TB UFS 4.1 | Display: 6.9-inch HyperRGB OLED | Refresh Rate: 120 Hz | Camera (Rear): 50 MP + 200 MP + 50 MP | Camera (Front): 50 MP | Battery: 6000 mAh | Charging: 90W wired + 50W wireless | OS: Xiaomi HyperOS 3 | IP Rating: IP68

CONTACT

Company: Xiaomi India | Phone: 1800 103 6286 | Email: NA | Website: www.mi.com/in/

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